The Demands of the Three Dikgosi were that:

- Bechuanaland should remain a protectotrate under the British Government and should not be incorporated or annexed into the BSACo.
- The autonomy and independence of their land should be preserved.
- Their land should not be sold.
- Liquor should be prohibited in their land.

They won the hearts of the British people and enjoyed a lot of support against the BSACo. They emphasized the need to remain a protectorate as agreed in 1885. As a result of their campaign, the office of Joseph Chamberlain who was the Sectretary of State for Colonies by then was inundated with letters from groups who protested the proposed annexation of the protectorate into BSACo. On realizing that the annexation might lead to an unpopular vote, Chamberlain changed his initial stand. He resolved the issue with the Three Dikgosi and agreed that Rhodes and BSACo would not get the protectorate but instead be allowed to get land for the construction of the railway line.

Eventually the Three Dikgosi came back home after 3 months on December 24th 1895 and were welcomed as heroes by many people.

THREE DIKGOSI

Khama III

- Kgosi Khama III of the Bangwato, Ruled 1872-73 and 1875-1923
- Born C. 1835, Died 1923
- Son of Kgosi Sekgoma I, Leader Of Mafolosa Mophato 1852
- Baptised by Rev. Heinrich Schulenburg 1860
- Fervent Christian, Moral Reformer and Temperance Advocate
- Welcomed 1885 British Protectorate, but Feared Loss of Land to White Settlers and Became Enemy of Cecil Rhodes

Sebele I

- Kgosi Sebele I of Bakwena, Ruled 1892-1911
- Born C. 4840, Died 1911
- Son of Kgosi Sechele
- Leader of Mathubantwa Mophato 1856
- Educated at Home by David Livingstone and by William Ashton at Kuruman Bible School (Moffat Institution)
- Highly Critical of 1885 British Protectorate Proclaim by Gen. Charles Warren

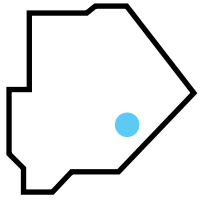
Bathoen II

- Kgosi Bathoen I F Bangwaketse Ruled 1889-1910
- Born C. 1845, Died 1910
- Son of Kgosi Gaseitsiwe
- Leader of Maisantwa Mophato 1864
- Educated at Home by Rev. James God, Champion of London Missionary Society, State Church and Temperance Advocate
- Initially Skeptical about 1885 British Protectorate Proclaimed by Gen. Charles Warren

Ntwa kgolo ke ya molomo!



Three Dikgosi
monument



Designation: Histrical
Area: approx. 3km²
Adoption priorities:
visitor interpretation centre, field assistants signage, trails

For further information, contact:
The Archaeology Division, Botswana National Museum
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Phone: +267 3974616 Fax: +267 3911186 / 3902797

BOTSWANA national museum

ADOPT A MONUMENT
GIVING LIFE TO BOTSWANA'S HERITAGE SITES

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Histrical Monument

Three Dikgosi MONUMENT

Three Dikgosi Monument was erected to recognise the initiative of the Three Dikgosi; Sebele Khama III, Sebele I and Bathoen I in particular, and of Batswana in general, in advancing their cause to gain independence, through peaceful negotiation and diplomacy; Ntswa kgolo ke ya molomo! (the greatest war is that of words). The monument is located in the Central Business District in Gaborone.

The story begins before this land was called Botswana. It is a story of first encounters in the land; of the hunter-gatherer peoples who had lived in the land for hundreds of years and later Bantu farmers. The period between 1823 and 1844, the people of Botswana had to build their own authority and resist invasion especially from the Kololo and AmaNdebele. These were two decades of fighting and turmoil in the western, central and northwestern areas which led to temporary breakdown and displacement of merafe or ethnic groups. The turmoil and fighting was mainly brought about and encouraged by gun trade and trade in game products. The more guns morafe or ethnic group had, the more the tendency to attack other merafe. The people of Botswana were also victorious against the Boers of the Transvaal.

With the threat from the Boers of the Transvaal, the leadership of different Tswana groups asked for British protection in the 1850s, but it was not granted. The London Missionary Society Missionaries in the likes of John Mackenzie, Robert Moffat and David Livingstone also tried to get British Protection for Botswana but they did not succeed. This was due to the belief by the British that Botswana was just a desert with no major economic value.

In 1885, Britain, suddenly declared that it had placed all the land of Batswana under its protection. When Charles Warren made the announcement, Batswana rulers were surprised that they were given protection at that time when they had not asked for it. Britain had declared protection mainly because it wanted to prevent German and Boer plans of expansion and competition in the Southern African territories. In particular, the British wanted to protect the road to the north which connected the Cape with Barotseland and Bulawayo running through Vryburg, Mafikeng, Gangwaketse, Kweneng, Shoshong and Ngamiland. The road was important because it was used by traders, hunters and missionaries.

The people of Botswana accepted the protectorate in which their land became known as Bechuanaland Protectorate. To them, being a protectorate meant protection from their enemies and not the involvement of the British in their internal domestic affairs. On accepting the protectorate, Dikgosi made it clear that they did not want Britain to take over their land and sell it.

Bechuanaland Protectorate meant that the territory was saved from Boer and German incorporation. However, a new threat of incorporation emerged from Cecil John Rhodes and his British South Africa Company (BSA Co). BSACo was established to colonise areas north of the Cape and the only way Rhodes could build the railroad through Tswana territory without opposition from Tswana rulers was to incorporate or annex Bechuanaland Protectorate as part of his company.

In July 1895, the Bakgatla, Bakwena, Barolong, Bangwaketse and Bangwato sent a petition to Queen Victoria opposing the incorporation of their land into the BSACo. This proved ineffective and instead of negotiating with Rhodes the Three Dikgosi; Sebele I of Bakwena, Bathoen I of Bangwaketse and Khama III of Bangwato decided to travel to London and take their case directly to Queen Victoria and the British people. They travelled with Reverend W.C. Willoughby who was their interpreter. The LMS organized their campaign in Britain. Between September and November 1895, the Three Dikgosi spoke against BSACo in over forty different towns and cities in Britain.











